

S A B B A T H

GENTLENESS AND SELF-CONTROL:

FRUITS OF LOVE

“But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, self-control; against such things there is no law.”

Galatians 5:22, 23

Let's learn about fruit from around the World:

DURIAN

In Thailand, durian is considered the king of fruits. It is one of the world's smelliest fruits and has a unique taste. To some, durian tastes like a mixture between scrambled eggs and flan (sweet egg-based dessert). It is usually a very large size and has a spiky, hard outer shell. On the inside it has a smelly, custard-like pulp with large seeds. It is a beloved fruit throughout most of Southeast Asia. Durian fruit is only grown in places with tropical weather. If by chance, the daily temperatures drop below 22 °C (72 °F), it will stop growing.

Most people will say “it smells bad but tastes so good!” This bad smell reputation has not prevented many people from enjoying its wonderful taste! It is considered a glorious delicacy.



TODAY'S SPIRITUAL FRUIT ARE

GENTLENESS AND SELF-CONTROL

Galatians 5:22 and 23 reads: “But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, **gentleness**, **self-control**; against such things there is no law.”

Gentleness has a special quality that is often included with other virtues fueled by the love of God. In Paul’s letter to members at the church in Ephesus he states: “with all humility and **gentleness**, with patience, bearing with one another in love.” (Eph 4:2).

Made up of Jews and Gentiles and a conflicting mixture of ideas and customs, Paul shares with the Ephesians that harmony in their church is only possible through the presence of God. Basically, believers must be filled with the Spirit of God to exhibit God’s love through the fruit of **gentleness**, among several others (and self-control, of course).

Like the Ephesian church, every family—even if both spouses are from the same ethnic group—contains differences of opinions and customs that often clash in the process of negotiating everyday life. Yet, if we are filled with the Spirit of God, we too can relate in our families with gentleness, rather than outbursts of anger and selfish ambition.

And then, **self-control**, which is self-explanatory. The person who bears this fruit of love is best described as someone who lives in his or her circle of control. Someone who is self-aware, who understands that the only person he or she can control is himself or herself. In our families we tend to concentrate on controlling what others should do—according to our opinions—rather than

concentrating on regulating our own response to what others are doing. What we know, based on the stories in the Bible and also the findings of social scientific research, is that the more we focus on managing our response—being patient, kind and gentle—as a result of being filled with God’s Spirit, the more peace and joy we will experience in all of our relationships.

In describing a home where the fruit of gentleness and self-control are in use, Ellen White communicates: “Every home should be a place of love, a place where the angels of God abide, working with softening, subduing influence upon the hearts of parents and children” (*The Adventist Home*, p. 18).

For this reason, our prayer today is that each family in God’s church will experience a greater measure of *Family Togetherness*, because the presence of God’s Spirit in the members of your family will produce the fruit of love each day. Love expressed in joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, **gentleness** and **self-control**, as you relate to each other until Jesus comes. So, pick the fruit of gentleness and self-control today!

May God bless us today and every day to walk by the Spirit, and together with our families be ready for the soon coming of our Lord Jesus Christ!

PRAY:

Dear Heavenly Father, You are so kind and gentle with us. Help us today to practice gentleness and self-control in every situation in all of our relationships. In the name of Jesus, amen.



FRUITFUL **GENTLENESS** ACTIVITY

You will need:

- A raw egg, or something else that is fragile but can be safely broken (you might like to boil the egg first if you will need the egg to eat later)
- A small plastic bag into which you can put the egg
- A box, several inches/centimeters bigger than the egg
- Anything you can find to protect the egg when it is packed into the box – such as feathers, moss, bubble wrap, tissue paper, soft fabric, cotton wool, etc.
- String, tape, etc. to secure the box

Instructions:

- Carefully put the raw egg into the plastic bag. This will help to keep the contents of the egg safe to use in cooking later.
- Work together, using the packing materials, to create a safe place for the egg inside the box, trying to make sure that the egg will not break if the box is dropped.
- Once you have packed the egg safely, tie the box with string or secure it with tape.
- Now, gently toss the packaged egg from one person to the next around the group.
- Each time you toss the box, describe one way that you can be gentle to others.
- When the box has been passed around the family 2-3 times, let the youngest person let go of the box so that it falls onto a hard floor.
- Let the oldest person in the group carefully unpack the box to see if the egg is still uncracked. Be happy together if the egg is all in one piece! You have been very careful to protect the egg!
- Discuss what you have learned about gentleness by doing this activity.

Alternative gentleness activities:

- Spend time learning how to care for a baby, or a young or small creature.
- Do a craft activity that requires a gentle touch.
- Go on a scavenger hunt for objects that remind you of gentleness.
- Spend a few moments being gentle in some way with each person in your family.
- Blow bubbles together – they are fragile and need us to blow gently.
- Practice cracking eggs, gently, without losing any shell, or breaking the yolk, and then make your favorite dish with them.

BIBLE VERSE — ACTIVITY —

- Say the bible text gently to each other.
- Or try writing the Bible verse on the ground outside, or on a wall, using a gentle feather dipped in water.

— **QUESTIONS** — TO TALK ABOUT TOGETHER

- I think gentleness is...
- Gentleness is a fruit of the Spirit because...
- Jesus was gentle when He...
- Other Bible characters who were gentle were...
- I find it hardest to be gentle when...
- Some things that help me to be gentle are...
- One time that I tried to be gentle this week was when...
- We can help each other to be gentle by...
- Pray: Thank You, God, for helping us to be gentle this week when...

FRUITFUL **SELF-CONTROL** ACTIVITY

NOAH'S STORY

You will need:

- A jar of buttons (or use nuts, small stones, safe seed pods, etc.)

Instructions:

- Take 5 buttons each
- Take it in turns to tell the story of Noah to each other without using the following words: boat, ark, ship, water, rain, animals, creatures, wood, dove, flood, mountain, people
- Every time the storyteller uses one of the “forbidden” words, they must put one of their buttons back into the jar.
- The winner is the person who has the most buttons left when everyone has had a chance to tell the story.
- Or repeat the activity until everyone has managed to tell the story without losing any of their buttons.
- You can repeat this activity with different Bible stories. Work together to choose the “forbidden” words.



BIBLE VERSE ACTIVITY

You will need:

- Paper, Pen or pencil

Instructions:

- Try writing Galatians 5: 22,23, using the hand that you don't usually write with or put the pen/pencil between your toes and try to write the verse.
- You will need to work harder at controlling the different part of the body to help you write!

— **QUESTIONS** — TO TALK ABOUT TOGETHER

- Being able to control ourselves is a fruit of the Spirit because...
- Jesus showed self-control when...
- Other Bible characters who showed self-control were...
- I find it hardest to be self-controlled when...
- Some things that help me to be more self-controlled are...
- One time that I was self-controlled this week was when...
- We can help each other to be more self-controlled by...
- Pray: Thank You, God, for helping us to be self-controlled this week when...

By Willie and Elaine Oliver with Activity Ideas by Karen Holford

Willie Oliver and Elaine Oliver are directors of the Department of Family Ministries at the General Conference of Seventh-day Adventists World Headquarters in Silver Spring, Maryland, USA.

Karen Holford is the Director of the Department of Family Ministries of the Trans-European Division.

Editorial Assistants: Dawn Venn, Karen Miranda.

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